

South Korea: Moderate Pullback in Early July Exports, Weighed Down by Ex-chip Demand

Bottom line:

Korea's per-workday exports in the first 20 days of July fell 2.3% mom sa, pulling back after two months of gains. Total exports during the 20 days fell 5.4% mom sa. While semiconductor exports stayed almost flat after nine months of strong gains, other tech exports dropped 11.2% and non-tech exports declined 5.6%. Exports to the US and Taiwan fell 10.4% and 28.4% respectively and together accounted for around two-thirds of the headline sequential declines. Total imports declined 4.9%, and the trade surplus (not seasonally adjusted) narrowed to US\$12.2bn from last month's historical high of US\$17.4bn.

Key numbers:

July 20 days' exports, adjusted for workday differences: -2.3% mom sa vs. previous: +8.2% mom sa

July 20 days' imports, adjusted for workday differences: +1.7% mom sa vs. previous: +8.1% mom sa

July 20 days' trade balance: +US\$12.2bn vs. previous: +US\$17.4bn

Main points:

1. Korea's per-workday exports in the first 20 days of July fell 2.3% mom sa, pulling back after two months of gains ([Exhibit 1](#)). Total exports during the 20 days fell 5.4% mom sa, down from +5.2% the prior month. On a year-on-year basis, total exports during the 20 days grew 52.4%, moderating for the second month from 60.2% the prior month.

2. Semiconductor exports stayed almost flat (-0.3% mom sa) after nine months of strong gains. However, other tech exports dropped 11.2%, weighed down by a sharp contraction in computer exports by 23.1%. Non-tech exports declined 5.6%, on broad declines across major products including petroleum products, steel, autos and auto parts.

3. Exports to the US and Taiwan fell 10.4% and 28.4% mom sa respectively and together accounted for around two-thirds of the headline sequential declines. Exports to other Asian economies including Hong Kong, Malaysia and Japan were broadly weak, whereas exports to mainland China extended a 9-month increase at a moderate pace of 3.4%.

4. Total imports declined 4.9%, also pulling back after two months of gains. Imports of machinery and semiconductor manufacturing equipment rose, but the gains were

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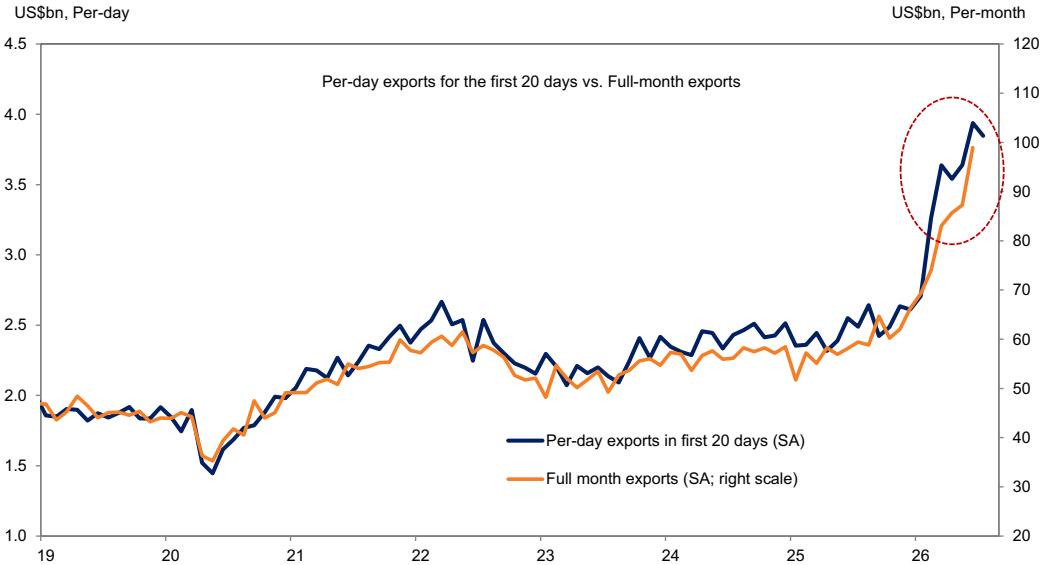
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offset by contraction in semiconductors, handsets and energy-related imports. The trade surplus (not seasonally adjusted) narrowed to US\$12.2bn from last month's historical high of US\$17.4bn.

Exhibit 1: Pullback in early July exports



Source: Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

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